COT & Midterm Context: NQ, Silver and the Rest

Prepared Fri Oct 30, 2026 (after the close) | Midterm election Tue Nov 3, 2026 | COT data: week ending Oct 27

Bottom line

- **Your rule (dashboard) says no COT edge on NQ, silver or gold this week.** The only index/metal-adjacent setup is BTC: Bearish (Commercials 12 vs hedge funds 100). EUR, GBP, NZD, crude and natgas show Bullish setups.
- **History says sharp NQ drops like this one usually see one more leg lower inside 4 weeks, then recover.** In 21 similar cases since 2007, 20 made a lower low within 20 trading days (median another -5.6%), but NQ was higher 60 days later in 16 of 21.
- **The closest analog is 2018, Trump's first midterm.** NQ was down about 6.5% from its high on election day after an October selloff. It fell another 19% into Christmas Eve, then was up 12% a year after the election.
- **After every midterm since 2006, NQ, ES and gold were higher a year later, and silver and gold were higher 60 days later.** That's 5 cases, so treat it as a tailwind, not a signal.
- **Silver is the closest asset to a Bullish COT setup.** Hedge funds (Managed Money) are at index 0, the bottom of their range. Commercials are at 62 and need 80. Watch next Friday's report.

1. WHERE THINGS STAND (VERIFIED PRICES, OANDA DAILY CLOSES)

Asset	Fri close	1 day	2 days	All-time high	Off ATH
NQ (NAS100)	28,410	-2.3%	-4.1%	31,401 (Oct 5, 2026)	-9.5%
ES (SPX500)	7,587	-1.3%	-1.9%	7,853 (Oct 5, 2026)	-3.4%
Gold	3,876	-3.6%	-4.7%	5,602 (Jan 28, 2026)	-30.8%
Silver	49.13	-5.8%	-9.0%	121.67 (Jan 28, 2026)	-59.6%
BTC	76,790	-2.5%	-5.5%	126,307 (Oct 2025)	-39.2%

NQ's high-to-low swing over the last two sessions was about 6.4% (30,045 on Tue to 28,111 on Fri); close to close it was 4.1%. Silver's Friday high-to-low was about 6.5%; close to close 5.8%. OANDA CFD closes at 5 PM ET, so they differ slightly from futures settlements.

Dashboard COT reads (your rule, governs the lean)

Asset	Commercial	Hedge funds	Non-Comm	Retail	Your rule	What would trigger a setup
NQ	28	86	69	75	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below = Bearish setup (others already 75-86)
ES	37	42	53	85	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below = Bearish setup (Retail at 85)
Gold	41	20	57	54	No COT edge	Commercials to 80+ = Bullish setup (hedge funds already at 20)
Silver	62	0	36	48	No COT edge	Commercials to 80+ = Bullish setup (hedge funds already at 0)
BTC	12	100	86	19	**Bearish setup**	Already on
US30	38	93	55	68	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below

Also on the dashboard this week: Bullish setups in EUR (C 90), GBP (C 88), NZD (C 91), Crude (C 93), NatGas (C 100); no edge in JPY, USD, VIX.

Two COT views disagree on NQ and silver. The historical tables below use the CFTC Legacy report with a 70-week index, the only report that goes back to 1999 for all four markets. On that method, today reads NQ **Bearish setup** (Commercial 7, Non-Comm 90) and silver **Bullish setup** (Commercial 100, Non-Comm 0). Your chart panel shows the same NQ picture (Commercial 19). Per your call, the dashboard decides the lean; the Legacy view is context only. Both views agree BTC is a Bearish setup.

2. COT READS AND PRICE ACTION AT EVERY MIDTERM SINCE 2002

COT = Legacy report dated the Tuesday before the election (what traders knew on election day), 70-week index. Returns are from election-day close, in trading days. "Max dip 20d" = deepest low in the next 20 trading days vs the election-day close.

NQ (Nasdaq-100)

Midterm	President	COT C / Spec / Retail	Rule	Prior 20d	+5d	+20d	+60d	+1 yr	Max dip 20d
Nov 5, 2002	Bush (R)	99 / 10 / 26	Bullish					no price data before 2003	
Nov 7, 2006	Bush (R)	8 / 55 / 100	Bearish	+3.8	+2.1	+2.4	+2.3	+24.8	-1.2
Nov 2, 2010	Obama (D)	12 / 87 / 49	Bearish	+7.9	+0.1	-0.3	+7.1	+7.9	-3.8
Nov 4, 2014	Obama (D)	86 / 22 / 40	No edge	+2.6	+1.2	+4.0	0.0	+11.4	-0.3
Nov 6, 2018	**Trump (R)**	63 / 43 / 31	No edge	+3.1	-6.0	-4.9	-4.7	+12.4	-10.5
Nov 8, 2022	Biden (D)	92 / 11 / 42	Bullish	+0.1	+8.6	+6.3	+16.2	+31.3	-0.4

Silver

Midterm	President	COT C / Spec / Retail	Rule	Prior 20d	+5d	+20d	+60d	+1 yr	Max dip 20d
Nov 5, 2002	Bush (R)	82 / 9 / 70	Bullish					no price data before 2006	
Nov 7, 2006	Bush (R)	74 / 30 / 20	No edge	+10.8	+3.8	+12.7	+7.1	+7.7	0.0
Nov 2, 2010	Obama (D)	25 / 67 / 69	No edge	+7.1	+8.3	+7.4	+15.4	+62.3	-0.4
Nov 4, 2014	Obama (D)	86 / 11 / 49	Bullish	-11.7	+2.3	+7.0	+12.4	+3.2	-6.6
Nov 6, 2018	**Trump (R)**	75 / 20 / 82	No edge	+1.9	-3.0	-0.5	+10.2	+21.7	-4.6
Nov 8, 2022	Biden (D)	79 / 22 / 19	No edge	+10.7	+1.9	+7.9	+6.1	+10.7	-2.3

ES, gold and BTC at a glance (+60 days / +1 year after the election)

Midterm	ES COT C	ES +60d / +1yr	Gold COT C	Gold +60d / +1yr	BTC COT C	BTC +60d / +1yr
2006 Bush	0 (Bearish)	+4.3 / +10.7	91 (Bullish)	+4.9 / +20.6	n/a	n/a
2010 Obama	90 (Bullish)	+8.1 / +3.2	20 (No edge)	+1.6 / +17.8	n/a	n/a
2014 Obama	61	-1.4 / +2.4	46	+12.6 / +2.2	n/a	n/a
2018 Trump	45	-3.9 / +7.8	81 (Bullish)	+7.6 / +21.7	2 (Bearish)	-47.0 / +14.7
2022 Biden	74	+10.3 / +9.8	95 (Bullish)	+9.3 / +17.0	64	+47.9 / +115.6

What the midterm history says

- **Post-midterm strength is real but small-sample.** NQ, ES and gold were higher one year after all 5 midterms with price data; silver and gold were higher 60 days after all 5.
- **COT Bearish setups on NQ/ES at midterms didn't pay.** NQ was a Bearish setup in 2006 and 2010 and ES in 2006, and all three were higher 60 days and a year later. The seasonal tailwind overpowered the positioning read. That's another reason not to force a bearish NQ lean from the Legacy view right now.
- **COT Bullish setups at midterms did pay.** NQ 2022 (+16% in 60 days), gold 2006, 2018 and 2022 (all up 5-9% in 60 days), silver 2014 (+12%).
- **2018 is the exception, and it's the Trump analog.** An October selloff, a bounce into the vote, then a second leg: NQ fell from 7,200 on election day to 5,802 on Christmas Eve (-19.4%, -24.7% from the high), ES -17.7%. Metals barely dipped (silver -4.6%, gold -2.5%) and were up 10% and 8% two months later. BTC, a Bearish setup that week, lost 47% in 60 days.

3. HOW THE COT NUMBERS MOVED AFTER EACH MIDTERM

Same Legacy 70-week index. "C / R" = Commercial / Retail index the week before the vote; "13 wks later" shows where they were three months on. Price change is from the election-day close.

NQ

Midterm	C / R before vote	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	13 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**7 / 54**				
Now (dashboard)	28 / 75				
2002 Bush	99 / 26	n/a	n/a	n/a	93 / 0
2006 Bush	**8 / 100**	+2.4%	+1.6%	+8.4%	39 / 37
2010 Obama	**12 / 49**	-0.3%	+7.2%	+9.6%	13 / 40
2014 Obama	86 / 40	+4.0%	+2.0%	+7.4%	100 / 62
2018 Trump	63 / 31	-4.9%	-4.0%	+1.4%	**100 / 14**
2022 Biden	92 / 42	+6.3%	+13.8%	+23.2%	93 / 34

- **2006 and 2010 are the closest COT matches to today** (Commercials 8 and 12). NQ still gained 8-10% over six months. In 2006 retail fell from 100 to 27 within 8 weeks; in 2010 Commercials stayed at 11-25 for six months while NQ climbed. Low Commercials going into a midterm did not lead to a decline.
- **2018 is the price analog.** Commercials started neutral (63). The December selloff flushed speculators, and by February 2019 Commercials were at 100 with speculators at 9: a Bullish setup that formed *after* the bottom. In 2022 Commercials were already at 92 on election day, at the end of a bear market.
- **Big NQ selloffs push Commercials toward 90-100 near the low.** Today they're at 7 (Legacy) or 28 (dashboard), so on this measure the selloff hasn't flushed anyone out yet.

Silver

Midterm	C / R before vote	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	13 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**100 / 22**				
Now (dashboard)	62 / 48				
2002 Bush	82 / 70	n/a	n/a	n/a	13 / 100
2006 Bush	74 / 20	+12.7%	+8.6%	+8.7%	56 / 31
2010 Obama	25 / 69	+7.4%	+10.6%	+50.2%	81 / 46
2014 Obama	**86 / 49**	+7.0%	+9.1%	+7.4%	**0 / 40**
2018 Trump	75 / 82	-0.5%	+7.6%	+2.2%	10 / 69
2022 Biden	**79 / 19**	+7.9%	+4.5%	+14.4%	36 / 49

- **Today's Legacy reading is the most bullish silver setup of any midterm since 2002** (Commercials 100, speculators 0). The closest matches, 2014 and 2022, rose 7-8% within four weeks, and silver was higher 13 weeks after every midterm with price data.
- **Commercials sold into each rally**: 86 to 0 (2014), 75 to 10 (2018), 79 to 36 (2022). A high reading usually unwinds within two to three months.
- **The dashboard has Commercials at only 62**, so your rule shows no setup. That's the gap to watch on next Friday's report.

Gold

Midterm	C / R before vote	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	13 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**74 / 51**				
Now (dashboard)	41 / 54				
2006 Bush	91 / 40	+4.9%	+6.7%	+10.7%	58 / 72
2010 Obama	20 / 67	+1.9%	+2.9%	+5.9%	100 / 27
2014 Obama	46 / 21	+6.1%	+8.3%	+4.2%	0 / 100
2018 Trump	81 / 54	+0.8%	+6.5%	+4.4%	47 / 59
2022 Biden	95 / 7	+4.7%	+9.3%	+18.1%	52 / 44

- **Gold was up at 4, 13 and 26 weeks after all five midterms.** The high-Commercial years (2006, 2018, 2022) match today's Legacy 74 best; each time Commercials fell back to about 50 within three months as price rose.

ES

Midterm	C / R before vote	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	13 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**58 / 71**				
Now (dashboard)	37 / 85				
2006 Bush	0 / 66	+1.9%	+3.6%	+8.7%	27 / 44
2010 Obama	90 / 70	+0.4%	+8.7%	+11.4%	53 / 50
2014 Obama	61 / 49	+2.6%	+1.7%	+4.4%	53 / 23
2018 Trump	45 / 31	-3.5%	-3.8%	-0.3%	**96 / 32**
2022 Biden	74 / 29	+4.9%	+9.1%	+9.9%	79 / 52

- **ES isn't at an extreme today; 2014 is the closest match** (61 / 49), a quiet, slightly positive period. **2018 is the warning case**: ES fell about 10% within 8 weeks, and Commercials reached 96 only after the low. ES retail is high today (71 Legacy, 85 dashboard).

BTC (two midterms of data)

- **2018:** Commercials 2, speculators 100, a Bearish setup like today's. BTC fell 43% within four weeks; Commercials had recovered to 82 three months later. **2022:** no setup; BTC was up 38% three months later.

Summary. COT readings at 80+ or 20 and below usually moved back toward the middle within 8-13 weeks after a midterm. In metals, high Commercial readings before the vote were followed by gains every time, with Commercials selling into them; silver and gold look like those years on Legacy, not yet on your dashboard. In NQ, low Commercial readings before the vote (2006, 2010) did not lead to declines; the one real drop (2018) began from neutral, and its Bullish setup formed after the bottom. If 2026 follows 2018, watch for NQ Commercials jumping toward 90-100 after the selloff, not dropping to 20. Each row is one election, five or six per asset: context for v7 signals, not predictions.

4. COT POSITIONING BY PRESIDENCY (LEGACY REPORT)

Term	NQ spec % OI	NQ price	ES price	Gold spec % OI	Gold price	Silver spec % OI	Silver price	Silver Bullish-setup weeks
Bush (R) 2001-09	-1.0	n/a	n/a	25.3	n/a	28.9	n/a	22%
Obama (D) 2009-17	15.4	+324%	+170%	31.9	+42%	21.1	+51%	20%
Trump 1st (R) 2017-21	8.7	+165%	+70%	32.6	+54%	18.4	+52%	20%
Biden (D) 2021-25	3.0	+61%	+57%	37.9	+47%	20.4	+19%	20%
Trump 2nd (R) 2025-now	8.0	+31%	+25%	**47.4**	+41%	26.4	+59%	**57%**

Spec % OI = average Non-Commercial net position as a share of open interest over the term. Price = term change (Trump 2nd through Oct 30, 2026). Setup weeks use your 80/20 rule on the Legacy 70-week index.

- **Gold speculators have been more crowded long under Trump's second term than under any other president** (47% of open interest on average vs 25-38% before). That crowding is what's unwinding now: gold is off 31% from January's high.
- **Silver has spent 57% of this term in a Legacy Bullish setup**, versus about 20% in every prior term, yet it's down 60% from its January peak. Commercials have been leaning long into a falling market for months. That's a reminder that a COT setup is a lean for v7 signals, not a timing tool.
- **NQ positioning is ordinary for a Trump term** (8% vs 8.7% in the first term). The crowding in NQ is concentrated in hedge funds (dashboard 86) and retail (75), not in the broad speculator group.
- Party or president, on its own, doesn't predict COT direction in this data. Every term had both setups. The useful part is the midterm calendar and the size of the current unwinds.

5. WHAT SHARP DROPS LIKE THIS HAVE LED TO

NQ: 2-day drop of 4%+ while 7-15% below the all-time high (21 cases, 2007-2026)

Horizon	Median	Average	Higher	Notes
+5 days	+0.5%	+0.5%	12 / 21	Coin flip through election week
+20 days	+3.0%	+1.7%	13 / 21	
+60 days	+6.7%	+5.4%	16 / 21	Losers: Nov 2007, Jan 2008, Oct 2018, Jan & Apr 2022 (bear markets)
Max dip next 20d	-5.6%	-6.4%	1 / 21 no new low	From 28,410, -5.6% is about 26,820, just under the 27,200 late-July low

Closest cases: **Oct 9, 2018** (Trump midterm, -9.4% off ATH): bounced 4.5% in a week, then -8% at 60 days. **Nov 11, 2018**, a week after that election: -1.9% at 20 days. **Mar 26, 2026**, this year's last one: +18% at 20 days.

Silver: 1-day drop of 5%+ while 40%+ below the all-time high (29 cases, 2008-2026)

Horizon	Median	Average	Higher	Notes
+5 days	+1.9%	+2.1%	19 / 29	Short bounce is the most common result
+20 days	+3.7%	+3.1%	17 / 28	
+60 days	+2.6%	+4.0%	15 / 27	Close to a coin flip
Max dip next 20d	-7.0%	-8.6%	0 / 29 no new low	Every case made a lower low; -7% from 49.13 is about 45.70

2026 is a falling market for silver. This year's earlier drops of this kind (Jun 4, Sep 9, Oct 13) saw further lows of 8-18% within 20 days, and the Jun and Sep cases were still lower 20 days later. Bounces have been sold all year, so the long-run averages above probably flatter the current setup.

6. DAYS AND WEEKS AHEAD

When	NQ	Silver
Mon-Tue Nov 2-3 (trade plan window,	No COT edge; trade v7 on its own. History is a coin flip for the next 5 days. Election-night gaps are possible.	No COT edge. A short bounce is the most common 5-day result, but every analog made a lower low within 4 weeks.

election day)		
Fri Nov 6 (COT for Nov 3, election day)	Key check: if dashboard Commercials drop to 20 or below with hedge funds/retail still 75+, NQ becomes a Bearish setup.	Key check: if Commercials rise to 80+ with hedge funds still near 0, silver becomes a Bullish setup.
Next 2-4 weeks	Base case from history: one more push lower (median -5.6%, around 26,800-27,200), then recovery. 2018 path (another -19%) is the bad case.	Base case: lower low first (around 45-46), then 60-day odds near even. Midterm history (5/5 up at 60 days) is the tailwind; 2026's downtrend is the headwind.
Into year-end	60 days later NQ was up in 16 of 21 drop cases and all 5 midterms. Losers were bear markets.	Gold and silver were up 60 days after all 5 midterms; gold COT Bullish setups at midterms all worked.

> **Limits.** Midterm samples are 5-6 elections, and the drop studies overlap with each other and with crises (2008, 2020, 2022). The Legacy 70-week index here is not the dashboard's calculation, which is why the Commercial numbers differ (NQ 7 vs 28, silver 100 vs 62). The dashboard governs the lean. This is historical context for your own rules, not a forecast or advice to trade.

Sources: CFTC Legacy Futures-Only COT (publicreporting.cftc.gov, NQ 209742, ES 13874A, gold 088691, silver 084691, BTC 133741), dashboard values from COT_Breakdown_2026-10-27.pdf, OANDA daily mid closes (NAS100, SPX500, XAU, XAG, BTC). Scripts: midterm_cot_fetch.py and midterm_cot_analyze.py (repo root).